



CURRICULAR ISSUES AND CONCERNS

- 2.1 *Introduction*
- 2.2 *Learning Outcomes*
- 2.3 *Significance of Curriculum in Education*
- 2.4 *Major Curricular Issues and Concerns*
- 2.5 *Conclusion*
- 2.6 *Let Us Sum Up*
- 2.7 *End Exercises*
- 2.8 *References*

2.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter focuses on major curricular issues and concerns arising from the children's diverse needs, abilities, and backgrounds, and, how they manifest, as well as how they can be managed by teachers in the classroom. It explains the concept of learning styles, the role of multilingualism, gender equity, multiage grouping, and the creation of an inclusive environment for diverse learners. It also provides strategies and actionable insights on how a teacher can create an accessible, equitable, and inclusive learning environment and what are the challenges that may hinder it.

Education and Curriculum



Notes

**2.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- analyses how individual learning styles influence curriculum design and instructional methods;
- explains the role of multilingualism in classroom learning and educational policy;
- describes inclusive education principles and their application in classroom settings;
- describes the effectiveness of multi-age grouping practices in diverse educational contexts;
- assesses curriculum content and pedagogy with respect to gender equity;
- identifies curriculum frameworks that promote diversity and inclusion;
- interprets relevant educational policies related to diversity, inclusion, and equity;
- creates lesson plans that reflect inclusive practices across all areas of diversity.

2.3. SIGNIFICANCE OF CURRICULUM IN EDUCATION

Curriculum encompasses all the experiences a student has to undergo in an educational setting to achieve specific educational goals. Therefore, it incorporates everything that is taught in a school through the prescribed syllabus and goes beyond that. It cuts through various scholastic and co-scholastic domains and incorporates components such as objectives, syllabus, content, pedagogy, assessment, classroom practices, institutional ethos, classroom culture, co-curricular activities such as sports, drama, field visits, and the overall learning environment. All these components help the learners to achieve their educational goals. Although factors such as teachers' capabilities, community and parental involvement, accessibility to education, and availability of resources, along with support from the administration, significantly affect the curriculum and the objectives it is supposed to achieve. The curriculum serves as a blueprint through which educational goals are achieved. Meanwhile, educational aims shape the content of the curriculum. The curriculum is often



a reflection of the priorities set by society, according to their social, cultural, economic, and political needs. It also has strong philosophical foundations that guide its purpose. These philosophies and the needs of society change over time, and the curriculum changes along with them. Based on diverse philosophical, sociological, and psychological guidance, various types of curricula, such as core, hidden, happiness, learner-centered, teacher-centered, activity-centered, and competency-based curriculum, are devised. The change in curriculum over the decades, such as the emphasis on foundational literacy and numeracy, arts education, cultural rootedness, digital literacy, information and communication technology, and a focus on interdisciplinarity, reflects the shift in priorities.

2.3.1 Diversity in the Classroom

Diversity in the classroom refers to the presence of students from different linguistic, cultural, social, and economic backgrounds, along with differences in gender, abilities, beliefs, worldviews, and more. A diverse classroom exposes the learners to various perspectives and broadens their horizons of knowledge. It helps them build their social skills, promote critical thinking, develop empathy, and encourages collaboration. The constant interaction between the learners of diverse backgrounds helps in removing prejudices and stereotypes as they come in contact with each other. Therefore, embracing diversity is essential to creating an inclusive, equitable, and effective classroom. However, diversity also has its own set of challenges that may arise in the classroom. We will be discussing those challenges in further sections.

2.3.2 Evolving Nature of Curriculum in Diverse and Inclusive Classrooms

As we have already seen, the curriculum evolves when priorities and the social, cultural, emotional, economic, and individual learning needs of society change. After independence, the advent of technology along with industrialisation has led to increased interstate migration in the country. It reduced the linguistic and cultural homogeneity in cities and promoted diversity in terms of language, region, culture, customs, and culinary preferences. This diverse nature of our country also becomes visible in the classrooms where students from different social, cultural, economic, linguistic, gender, and age groups come to receive formal education. Over the years, the principles of diversity, equity, and inclusion have become the cornerstone of various initiatives and policies. This has led to improved access to formal education, and a more diverse group of students is becoming part of the formal schooling every day. Therefore, it is essential that

Education and Curriculum



Notes

the school curriculum also evolves to cater to the needs of increasing diversity. The evolution of curriculum requires reflecting upon what is taught, how it is taught, and how it is going to be assessed. Therefore, it is important that the school curriculum also move from the traditional one-size-fits-all principle to become more personalized, flexible, and inclusive. Similarly, the content, pedagogy, and assessment need to move from a static, monomodal, teacher-centered pedagogy to a dynamic, multimodal, learner-centered pedagogy. The shift towards continuous and comprehensive evaluation is also a crucial step in this regard. It is important to understand that the curriculum can empower the learners by accommodating different cultures, languages, abilities, and identities. It can give them a voice and choice to exercise their agency.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.1

1. What is the significance of the curriculum in education?
2. As a teacher, while dealing with a diverse group of students, what should you do and what should you avoid?

2.4 MAJOR CURRICULAR ISSUES AND CONCERNS

Diversity is often a sign of richness in the length and breadth of a culture, but it also demands continuous accommodations to foster a sense of belonging in the classroom. Many steps have been taken over the years regarding curriculum and pedagogical practices to make everyone feel welcome in the school system. Despite this, there is a significant gap between the curricular policies and the ground-level reality, and often, curricula are not able to cater to the needs of diverse learners. This has led to the emergence of multiple curricular issues and concerns such as outdated curriculum, curriculum overload, gap between mother tongue of learners and the medium of instruction, lack of cultural, regional, and linguistic representation of diverse learners, promotion of gender stereotypes in prescribed textbooks, the digital divide along with a dearth of accessible content for students with disabilities, and differences in diverse learning styles and pace. Some of these are discussed in the upcoming section:

2.4.1 Learning Styles

Every person is a unique product of the dynamic interaction between them and the environment. Therefore, they comprehend the world around them in different

Education and Curriculum



Notes

ways. Despite people's cognitive uniqueness, there is some commonality between people concerning how they learn, comprehend information available to them, and make meaning of things around them. These preferred ways of learning information differently and consistently are known as learning styles. According to Dunn (1990), learning styles is the way each learner begins to concentrate, process, and retain new and difficult information. It is important here to understand that style and abilities are two different concepts. According to Willingham et al. (2015), Style tells us about how we do things, while abilities are concerned with how well we do them. Therefore, learning styles are not to be confused with the varied cognitive abilities of individuals. Apart from style and abilities, students also differ in their pace. The variation in speed at which people learn new information is known as the pace of learning. The knowledge of style and pace is instrumental for an effective teaching-learning experience in the classroom.

Learning styles are not to be confused with intelligence, as well. According to Gardner (2011), learning styles and intelligence are two different entities. They may overlap with each other, or a learning style maybe linked with a specific intelligence, or vice versa. Therefore, Gardner's theory emphasises how people have different types of intelligence, and it varies individually, but it is not to be confused with learning styles. Nevertheless, the theory of multiple intelligences also helps teachers to understand, respect, and cater to the diversity in the classroom.

Learning styles can significantly affect the school experiences, learning outcomes, and pedagogical practices in the classroom. Knowledge of learning styles can help in transforming the school experience for both teachers and students. A student with knowledge of their preferred learning style can improve their efficiency through focused effort, specific mediums of content, and comprehension. Similarly, those teachers who are aware of the learning styles of their students can tailor the lessons to the needs of their students. A coherence between how the teacher is presenting the information and the learning style of the learner can help the learner to absorb, engage, and retain the information more comprehensively. Teachers need to move from simple blackboard teaching to multimodal teaching and use an array of modalities and pedagogical practices designed to meet the needs of learners. Multimodal teaching promotes engagement of different senses and can effectively help learners from diverse backgrounds. There is no consensus amongst theorists

Education and Curriculum



Notes

on how to categorise different learning styles. Therefore, different theorists have categorised them differently according to their understanding. We will be discussing three different models of learning styles- the VARK model, Kolb's Model, and the Dunn and Dunn model.

VARK model of learning styles

One of the most famous learning styles models was proposed by Neil Fleming, called the VARK model of learning styles. The model categorizes learning styles into 4 categories - Visual, Aural, Read/Write, and Kinesthetics. Fleming introduced two visible modalities and made a distinction between students' preference for written text and symbolic information such as diagrams, charts, pictures, illustrations, etc (Fleming & Baume, 2006).

- **Visual:** Visual learners prefer information to be presented in the form of images, illustrations, drawings, maps, charts, diagrams, etc.
- **Aural:** Aural learners prefer auditory modalities to comprehend and retain the information. It includes listening to lectures, podcasts, audiobooks, and participating in group discussions, etc.
- **Read/Write:** These learners prefer to read and write texts, such as books, articles, and magazines.
- **Kinesthetic:** Kinesthetic learners prefer hands-on experience and physical activity, and comprehend better when engaged with tactile information.

Kolb's model of learning style

Kolb's theory of learning style is another influential type of learning style theory in the field. According to Kolb (1984), learning is a continuous process, and experience serves as the source for both learning and development. Furthermore, all learning is simply an act of re-learning, and a teacher's role extends beyond introducing the new ideas but also involves critical evaluation of pre-existing conceptions of learners. According to him, there are four types of learning styles- Accommodating, Assimilating, Converging, and Diverging based on a four-stage learning cycle. He expanded this concept in KLSI 4.0 (Kolb learning style inventory 4.0) and introduced nine types of learning styles - Initiating, experiencing, imagining, reflecting, analyzing, thinking, deciding, acting, and balancing, along with four dialectic tensions in the learning process. It includes the primary dialects of Abstract Conceptualization vs. Concrete Experience and



Active Experimentation vs. Reflective Observation, along with new dialects of Assimilation vs. Accommodation and Converging vs. Diverging within an eight-stage learning cycle. Learning styles are not fixed but keep changing in accordance with the interaction of the environment and the individual (Kolb & Kolb, 2013).

Dunn and Dunn's model of learning style

Dunn and Dunn's learning style model is a much more comprehensive model than the previous ones we discussed in this chapter. The Dunn and Dunn learning style model was proposed by Rita Dunn and Kenneth Dunn. According to Dunn (1990), it includes 21 elements that are classified into five categories (referred to as stimuli) that affect the student's learning :

- 1. Environment:** These refer to physical conditions that affect learning (sound, light, temperature, and furniture/ seating design).
- 2. Emotionality:** These refer to emotional and psychological preferences (motivation, task persistence, responsibility [conformity versus nonconformity], and the need for either externally imposed structure or the opportunity to do things their own way).
- 3. Sociological preferences:** These refer to preferences about social settings (learning alone, in a pair, in a small group, as part of a team, with an authoritative or collegial adult, and wanting variety as opposed to patterns and routines).
- 4. Physiological characteristics:** These refer to how the body and senses impact learning (perceptual strengths, time of day, energy levels, need for intake, or mobility while learning).
- 5. Processing inclinations:** These involve the way individuals process information (global/analytic, right/left, and impulsive/reflective).

The model also divides the learner into categories of analytic and global on the basis of how they process information, such as analytic learners prefer to learn in a step-by-step, sequential manner and tend to focus on details first. In continuation, global learners prefer to understand the concept first and then delve into minute details. Additionally, these learners also differ in their psychological and environmental needs, and the analytic learners usually prefer a quiet, well-lit, formal environment for an optimal learning experience. Furthermore, they typically do not take a break to eat or drink while studying

Education and Curriculum



Notes

and have a strong internal drive to finish the task. In contrast, global learners prefer slight distractions such as background music, conversations, informal seating, and food breaks during study. In continuation, these are just distinct ways to approach learning. It does not mean that any of them is superior or inferior to the other (Dunn, 1990).

2.4.1.1 Implications for Curriculum Design and Pedagogy

- Curriculum, pedagogy, and content should be designed in a way that caters to the needs of different types of learning styles. This can help learners to optimize their learning through multimodal teaching.
- Teachers should offer a varied range of learning activities, such as projects, discussions, and presentations, with flexible timelines to accommodate different paces of learning.
- Instead of restricting learning to a rigid formal classroom setting, teachers should allow students to choose from a range of settings, such as informal seating arrangements, open or semi-open classrooms, diverse lighting conditions, and flexible seating designs.
- Assessment strategies also need to evolve from traditional terminal examinations and need to include a variety of assessment practices such as structured tests, open-ended, closed-ended, creative, project-based, continuous, and multimodal tests.
- Curriculum should include elements that promote metacognition, autonomy, and self-awareness among the young learners. This will enable them to identify their learning style, pace, and take charge of their learning.

2.4.1.2 Challenges, Issues and Concerns related to Learning Styles

- There are major concerns related to learning styles. We often get confused between learning styles and the cognitive abilities of individual students. Furthermore, there is a considerable debate on the effectiveness of learning styles. Researches suggest that learning styles may not significantly impact learning outcomes, but still, it is very popular among the teachers community.
- Teachers often prefer their style of teaching instead of tailoring the strategies to align to the learning styles of the learners.

Education and Curriculum



Notes

- Learners often use mixed learning styles and vary their preferences according to motivation, mood, context, content, and the subject.
- It also presents the risk of learners self-labelling that might promote self-limiting tendencies among learners. A learner might limit themselves and resist adopting other approaches.
- Fixed timelines for syllabus completion, rigid curriculum, standardized assessments, and scarcity of resources limit a teacher in modifying their pedagogical strategies according to the needs of the learners.
- Lack of professional development, or limited training, increases the risk of misinterpretation or misapplication of the concept.
- Learning styles are not the sole factor that influences learning. Other factors such as culture, emotional or psychological stage, understanding of prior concepts, readiness of the learner, etc., also contribute to the optimisation of learning. Therefore, over-reliance on learning style while neglecting other factors may harm students' learning.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.2

1. What do you understand about the concept of learning styles? How is it different from abilities and intelligence?
2. How can the concept of learning styles be useful for a school teacher?
3. What are the major concerns and challenges related to the concept of learning styles in education?

2.4.2 Multilingualism

Multilingualism is the ability of an individual, group, or society to use and comprehend more than one language. Multilingualism includes bilingualism, which is the ability to speak two languages proficiently. A person may differ in their command over these languages. Sometimes they are equally proficient in both or more than two languages, while at other times they can speak one language more proficiently than others. Thus, proficiency in multilingualism is best seen as a continuum, with different languages existing at different points. Furthermore, these proficiencies may also vary with respect to different language skills such as reading, writing, and speaking. For example, a Marathi-speaking

Education and Curriculum



Notes

person might be very eloquent in Tamil because they have been working in Chennai for years, but maybe able to write a single word in it.

India is a multilingual country where multiple languages are commonly used. Constitutionally, India has recognized 22 official languages. Various factors such as colonial rule, globalisation, migration, the presence of different language families, rich cultural heritage, the rise of digital media, and educational policies have contributed to the rise of multilingualism in India. The multilingual nature of India is also visible in its educational policies, classroom practices, and assessment. The impact of multilingualism varies according to the context. Many languages are often used at the societal level and spoken in communities, but are not the dominant language in the country. These languages need to be integrated into the school curriculum to bridge the gap between students' home language and the school medium of instruction. Furthermore, this integration can help in preserving the cultural and linguistic heritage of the country. It can also enhance engagement, reduce dropout rates, and help students from linguistically marginalised communities to succeed without losing touch with their cultural and linguistic heritage.

2.4.2.1 Types of Multilingualism

When a person acquires two languages simultaneously, it is called simultaneous bilingualism. It happens when someone is exposed to two languages at the same time. For example, when children, whose parents belong to two different linguistic communities use their language in their household. The child gets exposed to both languages and acquires them simultaneously. However, when the child gets into the school system and becomes exposed to a new language that is different from their household language, they learn this new language and may become proficient in it over time. In this case, the child learned a second language after the establishment of the first language. This is known as Sequential bilingualism.

When a student learns a second or third language without losing proficiency in their first language and becomes proficient in each of them, it is known as additive multilingualism. It happens when there is a conducive environment supporting both languages. This helps the learner to maintain their cultural and linguistic identity as well as add a new language to their repertoire.

On the other hand, when a student learns a new language at the expense of their first language. It is known as Subtractive multilingualism. It usually occurs



when a child starts learning a dominant language and starts losing touch with their first language or mother tongue. Over time, the proficiency and fluency in the first language decline and are replaced by the second language. For example, Tanveen's first language is Punjabi, but her family moved to America when she was three years old. Over time, she became fluent only in English due to a lack of use of the Punjabi language in America.

2.4.2.2 Language as a medium of Instruction : Issues and Debates

In schools, students come from diverse linguistic and cultural backgrounds. Therefore, schools become spaces where different cultures converge and share their indigenous knowledge, including language, customs, and cultural practices. As an outcome, Multilingualism becomes an intrinsic part of everyday school processes. It helps learners and teachers to better understand and appreciate other cultures, improves learners' prospects of getting a job, increases intercultural competence, and enhances their ability to communicate with a wider audience coming from diverse linguistic backgrounds. Other cognitive benefits, such as critical thinking, problem solving, and multitasking, are also associated with multilingualism. Despite these benefits, the acceptance of multilingualism in schools is very challenging. The choice of language to use as a medium of instruction is a longstanding debate in the Indian education system. On one hand, English has become a preferred medium of instruction for many due to its perceived social standing as well as for utilitarian purposes. Its demand is continuously on the rise as many people see it as a tool of access, opportunity, and social mobility. On the other hand, advocates of education through mother tongue argue that children learn best through their mother tongue, particularly in the early years of schooling. Various cognitive, affective, and behavioural benefits are associated with the use of the mother tongue as a medium of instruction. Along with it, the spread of decolonising education over the decades has given ample space to local cultures and languages to claim their rightful place in the school curriculum. It has also strengthened the case of mother tongue-based multilingual education.

In India, most of the government-run schools embrace the policy of mother tongue-based multilingual education. However, the picture is particularly different in the case of private schools. Many private schools work on a monolingual principle to promote competence in the dominant language, particularly English. They exclude the home language/ mother tongue of the learner from classroom processes. This practice often creates problems/

Education and Curriculum**Notes**

challenges for learners to comprehend what is taught and express what is learned in the classroom.

2.4.2.3 Issue Concerns and Challenges Related to Multilingualism

When students from diverse backgrounds come to the classroom, they exchange their beliefs, habits, customs, values, and other aspects of language and culture. Therefore, multilingualism tends to improve intercultural competence amongst learners. It can help in fulfilling their local, social, global, economic, cultural, emotional, cognitive, and communicative needs. Despite this, implementing mother tongue-based multilingual education in its true spirit presents numerous practical and pedagogical challenges.

The concerns related to multilingualism include the dominance of the majority language, linguisticism, feelings of inferiority amongst minority speakers, mismatch between mother tongue and the medium of instruction, monolingual instruction in a diverse classroom, lack of resources and competent teachers in minority languages, identity crisis, biased assessment practices, stigmatisation, and exclusion based on language.

- In multilingual contexts, sometimes the dominant language presents a challenge to the survival of the minority and marginalised languages. For example, in the Indian context, dominant languages such as English present an existential threat to various minority languages such as Kuruk, Angami, etc. The loss is not limited to language but also leads to loss of identity, culture, and self-esteem.
- Dominant languages are often imposed on the students via school administrative policies, limited choice in choosing the medium of instruction, or unavailability of qualified teachers and scarcity of materials in a particular language.
- In a diverse classroom, students can become victims of bullying and stereotyping because they belong to a particular linguistic group that is perceived as inferior. This can make them feel ashamed about their own culture and language.
- A dearth of competent teachers, inappropriate pedagogical strategies, scarcity of appropriate teaching-learning material, assessment practices, and a lack of job opportunities hinders the promotion of the mother tongue as a medium of instruction.

Education and Curriculum



Notes

- Teachers are also not competent enough to teach in local languages in the absence of appropriate professional development courses in pre- and in-service teacher education programs.
- Many minority languages and mother tongues lack standardisation in terms of grammar, vocabulary, and orthography.
- Attitudinal barriers, such as feelings of inferiority amongst speakers of a minority language, prevent them from choosing mother tongue education over English medium education. They often prefer immersive programs in a global language, as that may provide them with much-needed social and economic mobility.
- Heterogeneity of the classroom in terms of multiple languages and mother tongues may complicate the lesson planning and the implementation of pedagogical strategies, along with assessment in the classroom.
- Education is often associated with achievement. Many national and international entrance exams, along with exams for jobs, are often conducted in dominant languages only. This can put students from linguistically marginalised communities at a disadvantage.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.3

1. What does “subtractive multilingualism” typically lead to?
 - a. Improved proficiency in both languages
 - b. Balanced bilingualism
 - c. Loss of first language
 - d. Enhanced cognitive flexibility
2. Additive multilingualism is best supported when:
 - a. Students are told to speak only the language of school.
 - b. Both home and school languages are valued.
 - c. The first language is discouraged.
 - d. All of the above.

Education and Curriculum



Notes

1. Why is the understanding of multilingualism important for school teachers?
2. What are the advantages or disadvantages of being multilingual for an individual?
3. What are the major concerns and challenges related to multilingualism in education?

Answer : 1-c; 2-b

2.4.3 Inclusion

Inclusion in education works on the principle that all children should learn together, wherever possible, regardless of any difficulties or differences they may have (UNESCO, 1994). Therefore, it ensures that all learners, irrespective of their abilities, backgrounds, or needs, have the right to access quality education in a common and conducive learning environment. It celebrates the diversity of learners in terms of their abilities, social, cultural, economic, and linguistic backgrounds, as well as differences in learning styles and pace. Inclusive education is an ambitious goal that requires the contribution and collaboration amongst various stakeholders. The scope of inclusive education is not limited to students with special needs, but also intersects with multiple domains such as language, age, gender, disability and socio-cultural and economic background. Therefore, it helps all the learners, not just the marginalised ones.

2.4.3.1 Principles of Inclusive Education

- **EQUALITY** : All students, regardless of their abilities, background, or needs, have the right to quality education. Furthermore, they have a fundamental right to be treated with respect and dignity independent of their background and/or abilities.
- **EQUITY**: Every student has the right to receive the appropriate, adequate support needed to achieve their potential.
- **ACCESS AND PARTICIPATION**: All students have the right to participate in all spheres of schooling. Schools must ensure that no students are left behind due to disability, gender, language, or other differences.
- **EMPOWERMENT**: Inclusive education emphasises that the learners



take control of their learning, claim their rights, and participate actively in all spheres of education.

- **RESPECT FOR DIVERSITY:** Inclusive education embraces the differences between individuals and does not discriminate on the basis of them. It celebrates people's uniqueness and promotes social justice.
- **COLLABORATION:** Effective inclusion requires collaboration among various stakeholders. It helps in promoting shared responsibilities, builds a stronger support system, and encourages teamwork and participation.

2.4.3.2 Barriers to inclusion and How to overcome them

Inclusion is a continuously evolving process that requires constant deliberation and action. There are multiple barriers that limit the access and the participation of individuals. Barriers can be described as anything that stops or limits a person from doing what they want to do. In the education system, it can include negative attitude, bias, stereotypes of stakeholders towards diverse learners, scarcity of appropriate infrastructure, learning material, lack of support system such as assistive devices, counsellors and special educators, communication and linguistic barrier, rigid curriculum and assessment, lack of teachers' professional development etc. These barriers can be broadly divided into three categories: Attitudinal barrier, Physical barrier, and Institutional barrier.

- **ATTITUDINAL BARRIER:** Our attitudes are often shaped through our socialisation. Therefore, they may contain biases, prejudices, and stereotypes towards a diverse group of learners who are different from us in any regard. These attitudes can be held by any individual, including teachers, peers, policy makers, and/or school administrators. They can hinder full participation and may create a hostile environment for diverse learners. These barriers are not usually as explicit as physical barriers, but can be just as harmful as any other.

Example: The perception that students who are studying through regional languages as a medium of instruction are not as academically bright in comparison to students who are studying through English as a medium.

- **PHYSICAL BARRIER:** Physical barriers are those obstacles that prevent individuals from accessing services, buildings, public spaces,

Education and Curriculum



Notes

and other infrastructural structures. These barriers are explicit in nature and present challenges mostly for persons with disabilities, but not only to them. These challenges occur due to inappropriate planning, poor design, and a lack of necessary accommodations. Physical barriers are also a result of attitudinal barriers in a way. Poor design is often a result of not acknowledging diversity and the diverse needs of individuals.

Example: School buildings that lack ramps, elevators, tactile flooring, etc.

- **INSTITUTIONAL BARRIER:** Institutional barriers are systematic in nature. It incorporates those policies, laws, guidelines, and procedures that systematically exclude or put certain people at a disadvantage. Therefore, prevent them from fully accessing various services. Institutional barriers are usually a result of not acknowledging or being unaware of the needs of diverse learners. They may also be an attempt to marginalise a diverse group of people or maintain the power gap.

Example: Denying students reasonable accommodation in the absence of specific guidelines.

2.4.3.3 Role of Teachers in Inclusive Settings

According to NEP 2020, “Education is the single greatest tool for achieving social justice and equality. Inclusive and equitable education - while indeed an essential goal in its own right - is also critical to achieving an inclusive and equitable society in which every citizen has the opportunity to dream, thrive, and contribute to the nation.” (p.24) Therefore, the responsibility of a teacher with regard to inclusion is not just limited to the classroom but transcends those boundaries. Here, teachers are agents of an inclusive society. Therefore, a teacher needs to be cognizant of the differences among their students and provide them with ample learning opportunities in a supportive environment. The role of the teacher is multifaceted and ever-evolving with the changing needs of learners. Before anything else, a teacher needs to reflect upon their own biases and create a positive outlook towards the possibilities and uniqueness of each learner. Once we overcome our own biases, only then can we recognise and address different forms of discrimination in the classroom. Teachers should avoid labelling students, ensure inclusive seating arrangements, and take steps to promote interaction among students from diverse backgrounds. It can help students move beyond bias and stereotypes and promote a sense of belongingness, mutual

Education and Curriculum



Notes

understanding, respect, and collaboration. A compassionate and responsive teacher can help in early identification, intervention, and the provision of flexibility to fulfill the social-emotional learning needs of students. Lack of appropriate resources and infrastructure is a long-standing problem in the school system in our country. But inclusion cannot wait, as the cost of not doing something is so high. Therefore, a teacher may also become a creator as well as a facilitator of inclusive learning experiences. They can create a space where students can voice their discomfort and find a viable solution with the help of the larger community. Teachers can also create and facilitate inclusive learning materials, pedagogical strategies, and assessment practices that cater to the diverse needs of learners. A culturally-responsive pedagogy, use of linguistic-cultural resources and collaboration with various stakeholders, can go a long way towards creating an inclusive environment.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.4

1. What do you understand by the term inclusion? Why is inclusion important in education?
2. What are the different kinds of barriers in the path of inclusion? How do they affect social justice and equity in education?
3. What is the role of teachers in an inclusive setting? How does it affect their pedagogy?

2.4.4 Multi-Age Grouping

In any school classroom, students come from diverse backgrounds in terms of class, religion, gender, language, and so on, but one thing that is usually common among them is their chronological age group. In traditional classrooms, students are grouped together on the basis of their chronological age, and any other kind of diversity is sidelined during this process. But do you think that students coming from a similar age group are also similar in their abilities and needs? In classrooms, it is assumed that the children who are chronologically in the same age group have the same level of cognitive abilities, skills, and educational needs. This assumption ignores the individual differences, preferences, and diverse pace of development among children. Therefore, it has led to the creation of a 'one size fits all' curriculum in schooling. Those learners who are not able to comply with this type of curriculum often fall

Education and Curriculum



Notes

behind other students, are labelled as slow, and may even become alienated. In this backdrop, multi-age grouping seems like a viable solution that breaks the rigid differentiation of grouping children based on their chronological age and grades. In a multiage classroom, students from different age groups and grades are taught together in the same classroom. The teacher focuses on the learner's readiness instead of age-based expectations. Therefore, they understand that the learners vary not only in terms of social, cultural, and linguistic backgrounds, but their intellectual, emotional, and social development also varies. It helps the learner with different abilities, competencies, and ages to come together and learn in a conducive environment that intends to enhance their learning. Teachers use tasks and projects to enhance exploration and problem-solving skills among the learners. The curriculum encourage students transcend the boundaries of disciplines and make logical connections across the subjects and disciplines. Thus, understand the things in totality. The approach is based on the understanding that multi-age settings, through cross-age interaction, promote collaborative learning, peer mentoring, and a more individualised educational experience.

2.4.4.1 Pedagogical Implications and Strategies

- Multi-age grouping enhances the social-emotional development of learners. Students from different age groups help each other as per their expertise in a particular topic. It helps in building a mutual trust between the peers and promotes cooperation and collaboration in the classroom.
- Multiage grouping allows learners to have a more personalised learning experience.
- Multiage classrooms are comparatively more flexible than traditional ones. Traditional classrooms are more focused on syllabus completion within a stipulated time limit. On the other hand, multiage classrooms are not as rigid, allowing students to learn at their own pace. Therefore, children do not develop feelings of inferiority complex, low self-esteem when they do not match up with the pace of their peers.
- In a multi-age classroom, an individual teacher engages with the students for a longer period of time. It helps in creating a strong relationship between the teacher and students based on mutual understanding, identification of areas of improvement, and recognition of needs of the learner. Therefore, it helps the teacher to design and modify their pedagogy and provide a



personalised learning experience.

- A multiage classroom opens up opportunities for better teacher-parent relationships. Thus, home becomes an extension of schooling, and parents become collaborators in the child's learning.
- In a multilingual classroom, learners become exposed to different perspectives. Younger children interact with comparatively older students, which can help in advancing their language skills and vocabulary.
- Teachers are able to accommodate students from diverse abilities, developmental stages, interests, styles, and paces.
- It helps the learner to design and modify the pedagogical strategies, material, content, and assessment as per the needs of the learner. Thus, promotes more individualised and personalised attention.
- Multi-grouping also promotes collaboration, leadership, peer support, and tutoring among learners of different ages. Students who have a better knowledge of a particular subject can help their peers. This helps both learners to revise and deepen their understanding of the content.

2.4.4.2 Challenges and Limitations of Multiage Grouping

- A multiage classroom requires teachers to deal with a diverse group of students and varying levels of abilities. Therefore, designing and implementing a curriculum that can cater to students with diverse needs and abilities is a difficult task.
- Assessing students fairly who are at different levels is also very challenging. Our obsession with merit, marks, and standardised testing does not align well with the philosophy of multiage grouping.
- Providing personalised attention and altering pedagogic strategies as per children's needs and abilities, is very demanding, particularly in a large classroom.
- Lack of professional development opportunities and scarcity of resources, limit teachers and force them to stick to traditional classroom setups.
- Standardised assessment, age-based curriculum, content, and textbooks are usually designed according to the chronological age of the learner. This further discourages teachers from abandoning the traditional processes.

Education and Curriculum



Notes

- The multiage classroom may also create behavioural and management problems. Older students may start dominating the class, bullying younger students, or resisting being part of groups with younger students, etc.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.5

1. How does multiage grouping challenge the traditional age-based classroom?
2. What are the advantages and disadvantages of using multi-age grouping in the classroom?
3. As a teacher, do you think multiage grouping supports inclusive education more effectively than age-based grouping? Why or why not?

2.4.5 Gender Equity

Sex is the biological classification of an individual into the categories of male or female based on their physiological anatomy. It is assigned to an individual at their birth. Meanwhile, gender is a social construct that reflects the expectations of society for different sexes. It includes social, cultural, and psychological behaviors that society considers appropriate for different genders. Therefore, it is not fixed but learned and varies from culture to culture and time period.

Gender equality advocates for the equal treatment of all regardless of their differences. Meanwhile, the concept of gender equity advocates for the fair treatment of all genders as per their respective needs. Therefore, it acknowledges and compensates for the historical and social marginalisation of women and transgender identities.

4.4.5.1 Understanding Gender and Its Impact on Learning

Gender has been highly intertwined with our language and day-to-day conduct. The language used in the classroom shapes the perceptions of young learners towards different genders, and gender also shapes language use. This reciprocal relationship has a significant effect on the identity of an individual. It shapes how one sees oneself, their aspirations, and expected behaviour in accordance with gender norms. In schools, pedagogical practices such as how we communicate with our students and vice versa are also affected by gendered perceptions. Even certain subjects, such as language, music, dance, and arts, are often associated with female gender as they are perceived to be more cultured,

Education and Curriculum*Notes*

meanwhile subjects such as sciences, mathematics, and sports activities are associated with male gender as they are viewed as rational according to the norms of patriarchy. Education and schooling work as a decisive force that can alter the social positioning/standing of an individual. It can challenge the long-held unscientific views, norms, stereotypes, and biases and turn an individual into a critical person. Furthermore, it can provide access, resources, social and occupational mobility, and free a person from the clutches of ignorance and false consciousness. Women make up around half of the world's population, but their representation in the educational system is comparatively quite low. The principle of gender equity advocates for women's participation and social justice in all spheres of life, but its ambit is not limited to or beneficial for women only, but it covers every individual regardless of their gender. The idea of autonomy and liberation is central to the idea of gender equity and education. The representation of women and the third gender is amongst the major areas of concern in education. Over the years, a vast array of special programs, policies, and initiatives have been started by the government. Along with it, various legal, constitutional safeguards, provisions such as affirmative action, scholarships, direct benefit transfer, etc, are also initiated by the government for women's education. NEP 2020 also suggests establishing a Gender Inclusion Fund to remove specific barriers and promote accessibility to quality education for girl children, along with transgender students.

The fundamental rights mentioned in the Constitution of India ensure that every citizen, regardless of their background or gender, has an equal right to participate and enjoy their life. But to what extent we have been able to ensure gender equity in the classroom needs deliberation. For a teacher, it is important to understand how gender stereotypes are manifested in the day-to-day classroom environment. School shapes gender identities and usually works as a springboard from which aspirations of diverse genders dramatically differ due to the pre-established norms of society. Certain career choices are categorised and labelled as not suitable for different genders. The concern of gender equity in education is temporally and spatially connected with the culture, institutional policies, attitudes of stakeholders, curriculum, classroom practices, and various other factors. The principle of gender equity challenges these normative and prescriptive values associated with different gender roles.

2.4.5.2 Gender Biases in Textbooks and Teaching Materials

Way of representation of different genders in textbooks is another major

Education and Curriculum**Notes**

area of concern in school textbooks. Many textbooks have disproportionate representation of characters from different genders, often use gendered and sexist language, promote fixed gender roles, and tend to give stereotypical portrayals of women and girls. The representation of the third gender is absent in prescribed textbooks. The contribution of women and the third gender is frequently overlooked, minimized, and omitted from these textbooks. Furthermore, these textbooks rarely depict women or transgenders in leadership roles and often portray them as passive, emotional and in need of care individuals. These textbooks often use the male pronoun as the default pronoun in sentences. Therefore, it promulgates the idea of male dominance in the psyche of learners. In the absence of appropriate role models, students tend to limit their aspirations and usually do not gather the courage to break the glass ceiling. Therefore, reducing the visibility of women and transgender characters and showing them in a particular kind of role, such as mothers, homemakers, and nurses, is not mere ignorance or a naive mistake but a deliberate attempt to maintain the status quo. In such textbooks, male characters are often shown as rational, active, independent, and driven by nature. Meanwhile, women characters are represented as passive, emotional, dependent, in need of care, and guided by culture. These representations shape the young minds of learners and limit their potential in so many ways. It has been observed that language and literature textbooks are particularly more vulnerable to gender biases, stereotypical portrayals, and can subtly reinforce them. Poems and stories often present an ideal of femininity and masculinity and inspire students to be like them. Gender non-conforming identities usually do not become part of the narrative. Moreover, female writers and transgenders are usually under-represented in the textbooks.

2.4.5.3 Strategies to Promote Gender Equality in Curriculum

Curriculum can help in legitimising the biases, prejudice, and stereotypical beliefs, towards certain genders. Therefore, it is important that the principle of gender equity is incorporated into the curriculum. The principle of gender equity ensures that no gender bias, stereotype, or prejudice is perpetuated through the textbooks, learning materials, and other classroom practices. It is hoped that all genders have fair and equitable representation in the textbooks, educational material, pedagogy, and assessment. Various elements of textbooks, such as the language of the text, images, illustrations, nouns, pronouns, stories, narratives and anecdotes can reinforce gender hierarchies and stereotypes. Therefore,

Education and Curriculum



Notes

continuous and comprehensive review of the curriculum is essential to maintain the content quality. Curricular change eventually and gradually transmits to the content and may help in creating gender awareness amongst young learners, but how a teacher deals with the content is even more important to yield the actual results. Therefore, continuous professional development of teachers is also crucial to improve the pedagogy and minimise the spread of biases.

- Curriculum makers and textbook writers need to ensure that all genders are fairly and equitably represented in the textbooks. It is important that they should include women and transgenders in various roles across subjects.
- Gender- neutral language should be emphasised in the textbooks and pedagogical practices.
- Teachers need to reflect upon the words, pronouns, and examples they are using in the classroom. Reflective teaching practices can help in minimising gender stereotyping in classroom practices.
- Ensure the representation of role models from various fields in the textbook to inspire students to achieve their dreams.
- Engage students in discussions on gender encouraging them to identify instances of gender bias or stereotypes in textbooks and school practices, and propose viable solutions for the same.
- Engage students in mixed groups with equitable gender representation in all scholastic and co-scholastic domains.
- Create a safe space where students can express, discuss, and find solutions to the problems they have faced due to fixed gender roles and expectations.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 2.6

1. What is the main difference between gender equality and gender equity?
 - a. They are exactly the same thing.
 - b. Equity only supports girls
 - c. Equality focuses on equal treatment, while equity focuses on fair treatment.
 - d. All of the above

Education and Curriculum**Notes**

2. Which strategy best supports gender inclusion in classroom?
 - a. Allowing the most vocal student to take charge.
 - b. Assigning all the leadership roles to the boys.
 - c. Assigning all the leadership roles to the girls.
 - d. Ensuring all students, regardless of gender, rotate through leadership roles.
3. What is the main goal of multi-age grouping in classrooms?
 - a. To reduce the financial burden on the school.
 - b. To simplify lesson planning for teachers.
 - c. To separate older and younger students.
 - d. To allow students to learn at their own developmental pace.
4. In multi-age grouping, students are usually grouped based on:
 - a. Chronological age
 - b. Developmental level and learning needs
 - c. Mood of the class teacher.
 - d. Alphabetical order
5. Which of the following theorists is associated with experiential learning and the learning styles model?
 - a. David Kolb
 - b. Jean Piaget
 - c. A. N. Basu
 - d. Sigmund Freud
6. A learner who best understands concepts through charts, graphics, and diagrams is a :
 - a. Dynamic learner
 - b. Aural learner

- c. Kinesthetic learner
 - d. Visual learner
7. Why is the concept of gender equity more important than gender equality for effective inclusion?
 8. Identify the different gender biases in textbooks and curriculum.
 9. As a teacher, how would you promote gender equity in your classroom?

Answers : 1-2; 2-d; 3-d; 4-b; 5-a; 6-d

2.5 CONCLUSION

Each individual is a dynamic product of the interaction between them and their environment. Therefore, individual differences amongst learners exist, and they can influence how a student learns, thinks, and interacts in the classroom. It includes differences in language, learning style, age, abilities, gender, motivation, attitudes, socio-economic status and cultural background, etc. Thus, a one-size-fits-all curriculum cannot cater to the unique needs of each learner. Acknowledging these differences can help in improving the learning outcomes and academic achievement of the learner. It can help teachers to accommodate diversity and to modify their pedagogical strategies to suit diverse learners. A holistic curriculum that makes provisions for diverse learners can help in promoting 21st-century skills such as critical thinking, problem solving, creativity, collaboration, innovation, and so on. It is responsive to individual differences and adaptable according to changing needs. It is learner-centered, inclusive, interdisciplinary, contextual, and reflective. Designing and implementing a responsive curriculum cannot become a reality without the collaboration of multiple stakeholders. The role of teacher education and professional development courses are crucial in this regard. A contextually aware and culturally responsive, reflective teacher can modify the curriculum according to the needs of the learner. In the Indian context, multilingualism, inclusion of children from diverse backgrounds, and gender equity are the major concern areas that require actionable insights. Some of the strategies are suggested in this chapter, but these issues are contextual and require constant negotiation, deliberation, and innovative solutions on the part of the teacher in collaboration with the larger community. Therefore, a reflective teacher is the main actor who can ensure inclusion, access, and equity on the ground with their contextual understanding and innovative skills.



Education and Curriculum



Notes



2.6 LET US SUM UP

- Curriculum encompasses all the experiences a student has to undergo in an educational setting to achieve specific educational goals. It includes both scholastic and co-scholastic domains.
- Diversity refers to the presence of individuals from different backgrounds in terms of linguistic, cultural, social, economic, gender, abilities, and more. Embracing diversity helps in minimising biases, prejudices, and stereotypes and creates an inclusive, equitable, and effective learning environment.
- Learning style is the way each learner begins to concentrate, process, and retain new and difficult information. It is different from abilities and intelligence.
- Learning styles can significantly affect the school experiences, learning outcomes, and pedagogical practices in the classroom. A coherence between teachers' teaching style and learners' learning style can enrich the educational experience of students.
- Multilingualism is the ability of an individual, group or society to use and comprehend more than one language. A student's mother tongue needs to be used as a medium of instruction. It helps in bridging the gap between a student's home and the school, serves as a foundation for second language acquisition, reduces dropout, and preserves cultural and linguistic heritage.
- Inclusion advocates that all children should learn together, wherever possible, regardless of any difficulties or differences they may have. Inclusive education incorporates principles of equality, equity, access, participation of all, empowerment, respect for diversity and collaboration among various stakeholders.
- Barriers to inclusion can be divided into three broad categories: Attitudinal barrier, Physical barrier, and Institutional barrier. An effective teacher can help students to move beyond these barriers and promote a sense of belongingness, mutual understanding, respect and collaboration.
- Multiage grouping breaks the rigid categorisation of grouping children into grades based on their chronological age. In multiage classrooms, students from different age groups and grades are taught together in the same

Education and Curriculum



Notes

classroom. It is different from multigrade classrooms.

- Gender equity advocates for the fair treatment of all genders as per their respective needs. It acknowledges the historical and social marginalisation of women and transgender identities. Gender equity challenges the normative and prescriptive values associated with different gender roles.
- Curriculum and textbooks may legitimise the biases, prejudices and stereotypical beliefs towards certain genders. Various elements of textbooks, such as language of the text, images, illustrations, nouns, pronouns, stories, narratives, anecdotes etc. can reinforce gender equity. Therefore, incorporation of the principle of gender equity, continued evaluation of content and the reflective pedagogy is crucial to maintain the standards of content.



2.7 END EXERCISES

1. How diversity affects the classroom dynamics and the practices? Does teachers' implicit biases influence their expectations and student outcomes in a diverse setting?
2. What are the different models of learning styles? How a teacher can accommodate these to improve the learning outcomes?
3. What do you understand by the term inclusion? What are the foundational principles it is based upon?
4. Is multilingualism a challenge or an asset? Evaluate the role of multilingualism in Indian classrooms.
5. How multiage grouping is different from the traditional classroom? What are the pros and cons of using multiage grouping in diverse setting?
6. How gender equity is different from gender equality? Design a classroom policy that ensures equal participation of all genders.
7. Imagine a classroom where diversity is fully embraced at all levels. What does it look like? How are curriculum, content, pedagogy and assessment practices different?

Education and Curriculum



Notes

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